

For three years now, Hell's Kitchen has held a Samhain story contest in an attempt to keep the Celtic new year alive in people's minds, hearts, and souls, rather than simply a time to harass neighbors for sucrose and plot various destructive acts. Samhain, is not the time of evil and horror that it has been portrayed as. Instead, it marks the time when Summer has lost its hold upon the Earth and the cold death of winter descends. On the night of Samhain, All Hallows Eve, the membrane between our world and the spirit world falls, allowing the spirits of the dead, gods, faeries, and demons to freely walk among men. The inverse is also true: man can enter into those rarefied realms.

But the night is not without danger. Anyone slipping beyond our world could be lost forever.

The act of writing, of creation, is our link to those airey realms. We bridge the gap between the actual and the possible. Poets, musicians, sculptors, artists of all kinds have always been portrayed as being more sensitive to the influences from those worlds. Be it Faust or Paginini, their imagination made them more denizens of those realms than to ours.

So, consider these stories a chronicle of journeys. These authors have willingly looked into worlds that aren't quite our own...and at a time of year when those boundaries are thinnest and rife with danger. Though maps of those worlds are as impossible to draw as a picture showing the location of waves on the sea, never-the-less, here there be dragons....

Dramatis Personæ:

Choices

Edward Heffernan

Fibber McGee

Edward Heffernan

Crimson Roses for Mary

Adrian Rossi

Grim Realization

Barbara Ann Flowerday
(with credit to K.L.F)

The Day the Snow Fell

Steven Bailey

Choices

-Edward Heffernan

Carl Richmond, the only employee stationed at the government freedom of life booth #59068, yawned as he clicked the switch to turn on the neon OPEN sign located above the booth. He shrugged off his lightweight jacket onto the metal and vinyl chair that was the sole piece of furniture within the booth, and proceeded to go through the morning ritual of getting a stained and cracked coffee machine to produce something that was actually digestible. As the machine bubbled away at its task, he pinned his plastic 'HELLO MY NAME IS' name tag onto his breast and peered out the Plexiglas window set in the front of the booth.

It had been a pretty slow week. Since he started working at the government freedom of life booth nearly a year ago, the protesters had dwindled from small crowds of place-card carrying demonstrators to nothing more than the occasional profanity shouted in the direction of the booth. And it had been weeks since he had heard even that. Carl wasn't sure if it was simply the fact that the people of America had gotten used to the idea of freedom of life, or if it was just because the government had had a booth installed in nearly every city in America. When something becomes as common as a McDonalds or a 7-11, it simply becomes background noise.

The truth is, Carl did not care. He did not know about the long senate debates that had taken place, the alarming amounts of anti-depressants that had been prescribed as freely as aspirin, of the computer models and charts founded on the idea of social Darwin, and how those charts pointed to the downfall of America. He might have seen in the papers the growing conflicts between the church and the state, on issues of morality and mortality, and the prime factor of the Constitution, free-

dom of expression. But he simply did not care. He had a fairly easy job, and was content to take in his \$6.75 an hour as a government employee.

It was a slow time of the year, the booth was usually the most busy around the holidays and weekends. Carl had been leaning back in his cheap government issue chair, sipping from a Styrofoam cup his second coffee-ish drink of the day, when the buzzer announcing a client went off. He sighed and leaned forward to look out the window to see what the morning had brought.

Standing outside, holding down the intercom buzzer, was a young woman. A little too young, Carl thought. She had black hair with the dull luster of the frequently dyed, black mascara applied around her eyes like an Egyptian from an 1930's movie, and black lipstick. Her eyes were red and puffy from what Carl guessed was a night of crying, and her mascara was smeared slightly. A fresh zit was ripe on her cheek, and her silver nose ring glinted brightly in the morning sun. Carl looked on her doubtfully, as the freedom of life booths had strict rules on age. No one under 18 was to be admitted, and the punishment if he did was he would immediately lose his job. So Carl spoke to her through the intercom.

"Ma'am," he said, "Do you have any identification on you?"

The girl nodded blandly and pushed her driver's license through the little slot of the booth and Carl glanced at it. The photo on the front showed the girl before him from a different life. Dirty blonde hair spilled over shoulders, and her bright smile must have lit up the entire DMV on the day it was taken. A total farm-fresh look, Carl thought. But the license said she was 18, so she was perfectly legal in her decisions. Carl shrugged and copied the name and address from the license into the little computer terminal on his little

desk. He left the license on the desk as he turned back to the girl.

“OK, now I am going to have to ask you a few standard questions, OK?” he said in a bored tone.

The girl drew in a shuddering sigh and a fresh tear ran down her cheek, but she managed to nod her answer. Carl picked up a dog-eared piece of laminated paper from under the desk. He had read it so many times that he knew its contents by heart. A few teens on skateboards rode by, probably heading for the Kmart that was located in the same plaza as the freedom of life booth. They snickered and pointed at the girl, but in general minded their own business.

“Do you,” Carl read “recognize that as a American individual and held under the laws of the Constitution that within your own free will you are expressing freedom of speech and decision, and that your own mortality is governed by individual choice and that none other than yourself has the ability to express this choice, so help you God?”

“I do” said the girl. She was staring at her feet as she said it.

Carl checked off a little box on his computer terminal.

“Right, now just one last question, why are you choosing to die?”

The girl looked up sharply. “It’s D-D-Donny!” she wailed. “He l-l-left me! And on my birthday! Donny was everything, I can’t imagine life without him. I can’t eat, I can’t sleep, and now I know I can’t live”.

Carl sighed. His coffee was growing cold, and he really did not want to listen to her. It was not his job. If she wanted somebody to whine to, the outside of the booth held several advertisements for counseling and psychiatric care. Hell, most of them even had an 800 number attached to them. He peered at a menu on his terminal for a moment, and

finally selected item E: 'the loss of enjoyment of life.'

“Do you have any last will or testament that you would like to have passed on to friends or family?”

“Yeah, hang on,” the girl said, and fished around for a moment in her purse. Carl noticed it had a teddy Bear attached to it. He had seen that a lot lately. What the fuck is it supposed to signify when a grown girl carries a teddy bear? But he lost the train of thought as he watched in disgust as she pushed a folded piece of notebook paper through the slot. It was even written in purple ink. Shit, he thought, she probably dots her i's with little smiley faces. He pushed the paper back at her, and tapped to a sign taped above his head at the window. It read, 'LAST WILL AND/OR TESTAMENT MUST BE SUBMITTED ON A 3.5 INCH FLOPPY DISK, ENCODED IN EITHER STRAIGHT ASCII OR MICROSOFT WORD FORMAT'. Carl mused to himself, Doesn't anyone ever read signs anymore?

The girl's mouth formed a silent 'o' as she read the sign. She glanced down at the paper in her hands a moment, and then dropped it. A slight breeze carried it away from the booth and across the Kmart parking plaza. Probably to end up in some gutter to be used as material for a rat's nest. She met Carl's gaze for the first time since she arrived.

“I guess not,” she said simply.

Carl nodded, and punched in one last bit of information into the terminal, then he instructed the girl to go around to the side door.

“Don't I get my license back?” she asked.

Carl gave her a funny look, and again her gaze dropped to her feet. Carl got up to let her in the side door, on the way there he threw her license into the waste basket. He buzzed her into the booth and brought her inside.

"OK, please proceed to the chamber in the back of the booth." Carl said, fishing in his back pocket for some gum. He could have sworn he had an extra pack. "Once there you will see a list of buttons with preferred religions labeled above them. If you do not have any particular religion, please press the button labeled 'no preference.' Do not linger in your decision, please. The government's time is the governments money."

The girl looked around. "So, that's it?" she said.

Carl nodded. "Yeah, that about covers it. Any relation or next of kin you might have will be notified via E-mail within 48 hours".

She hesitated a moment. "Well. Goodbye then," she said quietly.

Carl gave her what he considered a friendly wave. Hell, he wasn't all bad. The girl walked to the back chamber, while Carl went back to his seat at the front window. He had forgot to check the sports page this morning. As he scanned the headlines, he heard the door of the chamber slide shut under its owned power. After a moment, a scratchy recording of the final rites issued from a speaker within the room. The government had gotten the same voice that was used on Epcot's Spaceship Earth to recite the last rites. Nothing but the best. Funny, Carl thought, the girl did not look Catholic.

What happened next was fully automated, so Carl did not have to do anything else. After the recording ended, simple, quick, painless cyanide gas would be pumped into the chamber. After the human contents had died, the floor would open up, and the corpse would drop into what was basically a large meat grinder located underground. Once liquefied, the remains would be packed into a cubical saran wrap-like packaging, labeled with a barcode, and shipped off to the nearest freedom of life processing plant. Carl was not sure what happened to it after that. Maybe

they buried it. Maybe they cremated it. Maybe they fed it to pigs on government farms. He really didn't care.

Three more people arrived during the span of the day. One was an old lady who was simply tired of life. The next was a homosexual who had the HIV virus. He said he 'accidentally' contaminated his boyfriend, and felt so much shame that he felt he didn't deserve to live. Carl had made no comment. The third was a small Japanese girl, she had failed to keep a perfect 4.0 average in school, and her father had called her a failure and a shame to the family. She too ended up a cube with a barcode on it.

It was a half an hour before it was time for Carl to shut down the booth for the night when a final man appeared at the booth. He was frumpy and balding, and wore an ill fitting cheap suit with sweat stains under his arms, even though the October night was cool. Carl calmly took his license, and copied down the information. He then asked the man the reason he wished to end his life.

"It's my wife," he said. "I came home today, and she was in bed. With another man. My wife. Seventeen years of marriage." He hid his face in his hands and his shoulders shook.

Carl nodded indifferently, and buzzed him in the side door. He tossed the mans license in the growing pile located in the wastebasket, and then went through the ritual of explaining the use of the buttons for choice of last rights.

"Do you understand...?" Carl asked. The man made no comment, but proceeded down the corridor to the chamber. Carl shrugged and went back to the front of the booth, where he started cleaning the coffee pot for the next days use. Behind him, the chamber's door slid shut, and light elevator music drifted out from under the chamber's door. So the man had pressed 'no preferences' Carl

thought mildly.

Carl was just dumping the basket of license into the main garbage can, when he heard a pounding on the door of the chamber, and the voice of the frumpy man drifted out from underneath.

"Hello?!" the voice called, "Um, I think I changed my mind. Honest. I don't want to die. I've done nothing wrong, it was that bitch! I realize that now, that bitch of a wife! Hello? Hello?!"

Carl paused and gritted his teeth. Damn. As so close to closing time, too. He just wanted to go home, pop the top off a beer, and watch a little television. He eyed the bright red ABORT button located next to the terminal. It was within the mans right to be let out. But that would require almost an hour of paper work for Carl, explaining why the man chose not to express his freedom of life. Carl drummed his fingers lightly on his desk as the mans voice rose in volume and pitch. Coherent words broke off into the raving babbles of a man condemned to die, but who does not wish it. Finally Carl made a decision. It was not like a supervisor was looking over his shoulder.

He turned off the light, locked up, and went home.

Third Place



Crimson Roses for Mary

-Adrian Rossi

Someone was whistling.

It was a dreamy yet piercing sound, ricocheting through the quiet park air like bullets from the clip of a 9mm Uzi. At least that was the impression of the couple that looked up at the sound. They were seated beside each other on a weathered park bench, enjoying the calm Autumn afternoon, and lifted their head from their private conversation just in time to see the stranger walk by. One of them, a blonde-haired young woman, giggled a little and whispered to her dark-haired companion.

"I think he's in love"

If the man heard this, he gave no indication of it as he continued along his way. He was a white male dressed in dark blue dress pants with a tan windbreaker wrapped about his thin form. The man was somewhere in his twenties, or perhaps thirties or forties; it was impossible to tell. He had a smooth pale complexion, devoid of any freckles or beauty marks, framed by short-cropped dark hair and sharp hazel eyes. The striking thing about this man was that he possessed the most unremarkable face. It was just one in a crowd of millions. The almost-smile on his face, the odd Mona Lisa smile, was the only memorable detail. It was almost as if, had the man ceased to smile, he would have ceased to exist. There are those that might say that the way a man looks would give some indication of his social and political ideologies. If such people were to gaze at this man, they would quickly discover that classifying him was an impossible task.

In one gloved hand dangled a bouquet of thorny red roses. The man glanced down as he walked, adjusting his grip, and returned his curious gaze to the concrete path before him. People would cast him odd looks now and then, as if he was Michael Jackson walk-

ing in Times Square, to which he returned that same vacuous smile. *THERE WAS NOTHING ODD ABOUT THE GLOVE*, the man thought to himself, *HE HAD TO GUARD AGAINST THORNS COVERING HIS HAND IN BLOOD*. He continued to walk, slowly and without hurry, winding his way through the sculptured bushes and trimmed grass fields of the park. He was enjoying himself, as warm days like this in the usually cold month of October were to be savored. Like a glass of wine at an expensive crazy-sounding restaurant.

The man continued to walk, continued to ignore the looks that were cast his way. The bushes and grasses of the park fell away to reveal the black asphalt of a parking lot covered in shining cars that reflected the sun. He glanced upwards, and saw that he was in the city again, where the skyscrapers towered over the tiny oasis of nature in a vast concrete jungle. For now, the only building that interested him was a tall apartment complex across on the other side of the parking. He regarded it for a moment, thinking its bright pink shading was a rather feeble attempt to make the building look modern, and began walking again.

He passed into the lobby of the apartment complex, pushing through the swinging glass doors to step into its polished interior. He glanced about and saw a few people standing over by the counter, being helped by white attired employees of the apartment. The lobby narrowed into a short corridor that tapered off to a glass wall. The stranger slipped by the desk, the distracted people not taking close notice of the man, perhaps assuming he was a resident of the complex. He made his way to one of the four elevator doors and pressed the button. As luck would have it one of the cars was idling on the ground floor and the doors opened with a weird electronic beep that reminded the man oddly of some antique arcade game.

He stepped inside the empty elevator. An

electronic voice asked him which floor to which he would like to be taken, and he pressed fourteen. The doors closed, and he had a brief moment of vertigo as the elevator eased into motion. The man waited, watching the numbers slip by, and he glanced at his reflection in the mirrored walls of the elevator. Why did they do that? Put mirrors on the walls, that is. It was almost as if you were expected to take an effort yourself look pretty before showing up at some tenant's door.

The man's thoughts were interrupted as the elevator came to a slow halt on floor fourteen. It beeped again, that same odd sound, and the door slid open with a hiss. He stepped out into the corridor, and made his way down the empty hallway. He stopped before a door at the very end of the corridor, room number 1401. The man took in a deep breath and knocked on the door.

There was a hesitation, then it swung open. In the open doorway there stood a petite blond dressed in torn jeans and a t-shirt that said 'Life's a bitch'. The man blinked, then smiled in recognition.

"Mary," he said, and held out the roses to her.

GOD, SHE WAS SO BEAUTIFUL.

She began to smile and reached out for the flowers. The man grabbed the outstretched hand, shoved into the apartment, and slammed the door behind him. His other hand tightened about the hammer hidden in the roses, raising it. She was startled. Her blue eyes widened, and she opened her mouth to scream.

NO! He was suddenly enraged. *NOT LIKE THAT!*

He swung the hammer. He swung to stop the scream, to kill it, to end it before it began. He swung the hammer and hit her on the side of the head. Mary reeled backwards into the living room of the apartment, and then collapsed backwards onto a rug that was

unfurled there. But he wasn't finished. The man stepped over her, raising the hammer again, enraged. She'd tried to scream! Didn't she want him to love her? She'd refused him once before and left him, but not again. Oh no, not again. The hammer fell, then rose, and fell again. Blood sprinkled the eyes, crystallizing in the light and falling to the ground in splatters. And rose. And fell. By the fourteenth, he stopped, breathing heavily, and reasoned that two swings would have done the job. But at that thought a voice rose up inside his mind, taking the voice of his father. The man paused, tilting his head, listening. *IF YOU DO IT HALF-ASSED THE FIRST TIME, SON, the voice warned ominously, IT'S GONNA COME BACK TO HAUNT YOU.*

"I know," he said, rising to his feet to stare down at the broken form of his love, "but she's dead, Dad."

And she was. Lying upon the ground, her life's blood seeping into the rug where she fell, the body was nothing except an empty shell. Her head was an unrecognizable tangle of blond hair and bloodied folds of mangled skin. But that was okay. He had the memory of her face in his mind, where it would be eternally young and beautiful. Wherever Mary had been before, she wasn't trapped anymore. The man smiled. He'd set her free, as he promised her he would. He was standing there, giving that odd smile down at the body, and dropped the roses on the body. Soaked in blood, they were a garish crimson color in the dim light from the corridor. The man glanced down at himself, and noticed that his glove had indeed kept blood from covering his hand, after all.

His head tilted. Voices. They were speaking to him again. Many of them. Telling him what to do.

YOU GOTTA GO, one of them warned him. He got the impression it was a police officer, but there had been three of them. He wasn't

sure which one it was. *THERE ARE SOME VERY BAD PEOPLE COMING AND THEY MIGHT HURT YOU*, another added. He sighed, smiling. Whatever would he do without his Mom? *COME ON, SON, GET YOUR ASS MOVING*. No questioning that one.

"Where do I go?" he lifted his head, speaking into the air. And the emptiness responded, not so much in words as in feelings, as in a sense of what was right to do and what was wrong. For a long moment the man stood silently, listening.

Then he turned. The man stepped out of the room, shut the door. He crossed over the hallway and opened up the trash disposal door. He stared down into the dark abyss of the opening for a moment, feeling a cool rush of air hit him from the shaft, and then pulled off his glove and cast it into the darkness. It fell soundlessly and vanished. The bloodied hammer followed. The man glanced down at his watch. Five to four. If the garbage truck came right on schedule at the turn of the hour then the hammer and glove would be on its way to the dump at the city limits before he even got home.

He closed the disposal with a creaking of hinges and turned away. He chose to take the stairs rather than the elevator. Why? They told him to. And the voices were always right.

* * *

Back in the Park.

A passing elderly couple saw the man as he went by, noted the obvious stance and walk of a man deeply in love. The old woman smiled at the look on the man's face, and then nudged her husband in the side.

"*Why don't you look like that at me anymore?*" the man heard her demand.

The man didn't hear the old man's reply. He was now ignoring them. He was thinking of nothing else except him and his beloved

Mary, with whom he would now have for the rest of eternity. Gradually the smile upon his face widened and became dreamy once more. Above the man, birds chirped and flew at each other in the canopy of the trees. To the side, people were quietly conversing in the afternoon sun, the cries of playing children echoing through the warm afternoon air. The man noticed nothing of this, suddenly aware that someone was speaking to him. *LOOK RAY, it said, ISN'T IT BEAUTIFUL?* His breath caught in his throat as he recognized the new voice, his

heart suddenly soaring with happiness. It was female, not anything like any of the other ones he'd taken. He paused and lifted his head to regard the sun. The autumn day, God, she was so right. It was so beautiful. Just like she was and will always be.

He smiled and continued along his way.

After a while he began to whistle again.

Honorable Mention

The Day the Snow Fell

-Steven Bailey

Paul Saunders had been at his site for three months now. He was a 23-year-old American Peace Corps volunteer assigned to teach English on the tiny coral atoll of Rapa Nui. By day he taught grammar in the little cinder-block school; by night he sat in his hut—a thatched affair perched on stilts above sandy, chicken-pecked soil — and listened to the BBC, talked to the locals, and wrote lesson plans. It seemed to Paul that life in Rapa Nui flowed with the slow charm of a tropical paradise.

Most of the time, Paul admitted to himself, he didn't know what the fuck was going on. He'd grown up in North Dakota, a landlocked state with long winters, and this little South Pacific island, with its palm trees and searingly hot afternoons, left him baffled. Still, he was slowly adjusting. He'd learned how to drink from coconuts; he'd learned how to cook taro root. He'd begun to get a grip on the local tongue, Lapa. Most importantly, he'd learned to stay away from the water.

Stay out of the water. This was the very first thing that the islanders told Paul when he arrived at the dusty airstrip of crushed coral. Paul knew that he might be a hick from

North Dakota, but he'd seen the movie *Jaws*, and grasped immediately that the locals did not want their brand-new English teacher to be shark-food. But then Paul's knowledge of Lapa failed him, for he thought that the islanders said: We haven't swam since the day the snow fell.

* * *

Paul took the islanders' advice at face value, and though the clear aqua waters of the lagoon looked inviting during the hot afternoons, he never swam there. But one day, after many long hours of teaching somnolent, sun-dazed twelve-year-olds, Paul waded out into the lagoon up to his bony white knees. What was the harm? he thought. The water shimmered so clear, surely he'd see any sharks long before they got too close.

The water felt wonderful, and Paul sat on the sandy bottom of the lagoon, the warm water rising to his navel. From this sitting position, a trick of the sun rendered the water a blinding, opaque sheet of white. Paul found the effect hypnotizing, and he sat like that for what seemed a long time. He thought of the cold whiteness covering his home town at this time of year, and the whiteness of people's skin there. Whiteness, he thought, was familiar, comforting.

With a start, Paul realized that the water before him had grown choppy and disturbed.

He sensed that something moved unseen beneath the roiled surface of the water. Frightened, Paul lurched to his feet, and once standing he could see a large, indistinct form moving towards him in a zig-zag fashion. Paul hurled himself at the beach; behind him he heard thrashing sounds in the water. When he'd reached the safety of dry land he turned. Looking down into that clear blue water, now distorted with splashes and ripples and boiling clouds of sand, he thought he saw, for one terrifying moment, a giant snake. But his mind rejected the idea immediately as a trick of the sun; he'd obviously seen a big and hungry shark.

* * *

As Paul spent more time on the island he noticed something strange. Not only did the islanders not swim or wade, they didn't venture out upon the water in boats either. Nor did they eat fish. In various forgotten corners of the island Paul stumbled across outrigger canoes beached far above the high-tide mark, half-full of sand or covered in flowery undergrowth. The only boat on Rapa Nui was the once-a-month supply ship: a World War II landing craft that beached itself like a fat grey whale on the coral sand to unload crates of beer and video machines and cans of Spam and corrugated metal roofing--all the things that were quickly supplanting local customs and traditions.

Paul's Lapa had improved to the point where he could carry on extended conversations. "Most honorable Chief, what happened to the canoes?" he asked Chief Narulo one hot Sunday afternoon. "Why don't your people use them anymore?"

Chief Narulo was very old and fat; a single long black whisker grew from his chin. "When I was young I sailed all over these islands," he said. "But then came the day of the two suns."

"The day of the two suns?" Paul asked.

"Yes, the day of the two suns. The day the snow fell."

Paul wondered why his Lapa always failed him when he needed it most.

* * *

Rapa Nui was a small island, and everything on it was held communally under the stewardship of Chief Narulo. A modest number of bony chickens and scrawny dogs numbered among these community assets. These animals belonged to everybody and nobody, and on feast days a few choice birds and dogs went into the pot.

One night, asleep in his stilt hut, Paul awoke to the sound of howling, whining and barking dogs. He crawled out from under his mosquito net and shone his flashlight out into the darkness. He saw only palm trees and low thickets.

Paul shrugged, and went back to bed.

* * *

When Paul had an audience with Chief Narulo the next day he found him in a testy mood. Somebody, the Chief explained, had been eating the communal dogs and chickens without his permission. This annoyed the Chief, but what really disturbed him was the fact that on this tiny island of a few hundred people, the Chief could not identify the culprit. Paul realized that as the lone outsider, and a freak-skinned one at that, he remained the prime suspect.

Paul thought only a guilty man would attempt to persuade the Chief of his innocence, so he kept his silence on the issue and changed the subject: "Most honorable Chief, tell me about the day of the two suns. Tell me about the day the snow fell."

The Chief leaned back in his wicker chair and did not reply for a long time. Paul had learned not to interrupt these long reveries. Finally, as Paul knew he would, the old Chief spoke.

"In your years it was 1953. To your people the year holds no significance. To my people it was the year we fell out of favor with the Gods. One day in that year the sun rose and we went about our business. But then, a second sun rose in the north, blood red and horrible, and it spoke to us, grumbling like thunder. We had displeased the Gods with our selfish ways, and this was our punishment. Then the snow fell. Yes, my young friend, it was snow as you have in your country. Carpeting the island and floating upon the sea."

Something clicked in Paul's mind. He remembered a documentary that a radical history professor had forced him to watch. The topic: nuclear testing in the South Pacific. Paul had not been all that interested, but one scene from the film stuck in his mind: an awe-struck American serviceman describing the aftermath of a nuclear test on Bikini Atoll. The fallout drifted down, said the man, like pure white snowflakes in a radioactive blizzard.

"And for many years my people were sick," the Chief continued. "Ay! My father died that same year, 1953, and I became Chief. And the fish of the sea turned evil, and our men disappeared while fishing in their canoes, and children vanished in the lagoon. ~~Now, thirty years later, we accept~~ the punishments of the Gods. We do not go to sea; it is taboo to touch saltwater or to eat fish. I have decreed it so."

* * *

That night the yammering of the dogs woke Paul once again. He stepped out onto the porch of his hut, and with the full moon, he didn't need the flashlight. The dogs sounded close, and as Paul listened their frenzied barking faded abruptly into fearful whining and, finally, complete silence.

Paul heard something breaking through the undergrowth, moving fast, and before he

could search for a weapon, or at least retreat inside, a small black form burst out of the shadows. With a yelp it bounded up the ladder, slipped through Paul's legs, and disappeared into the hut.

With a sigh of relief, Paul recognized Sparky, his favorite of the communal dogs. The little mongrel shivered miserably in one corner, tail between its legs, eyes glazed with fear. Paul knew dog behavior well; his family had probably owned a dozen in his lifetime. Paul knew that when dogs truly fear something, they run to their masters for protection.

Paul felt a sudden acid jolt of fear. Whatever had scared the dog could very well turn up outside his hut. He shut the rickety thatch door and spent a sleepless night huddled with Sparky, his big rubber EverReady flashlight his only weapon. Once he thought he heard screams of terror; once he thought he heard a curious crunching sound, like the sound of a heavy object being dragged over the sand. Once he swore he heard it beneath the hut, and at that precise moment Sparky whined and pissed all over both of them. At sunrise Paul dozed off to the smell of dog urine and his own sweaty fear.

* * *

Paul woke at midday to the sound of women wailing in grief. When he and Sparky went to investigate, they found nearly the entire island congregated in two groups on the beach. A weird, zig-zagging trail in the sand divided the two groups.

"What is that?" Paul asked Popidou, a pot-bellied islander who doubled as the school's math and science teacher.

"It is the trail of the Serpent."

Paul examined the sand. He had to admit, it did look like a giant snake had slithered down the beach and into the lagoon.

"The Serpent came in the night. It took a child," Popidou said, and for the first time

Paul noticed the cold terror lurking under the islanders' loud cries of bereavement.

"A giant snake?" Paul said, using different Lapa words. He wanted to double-check that he'd got it right.

"Yes. A giant Sea-serpent. It came in the night. It swallowed the boy. I saw it with my own eyes." Popidou shivered. "It was horrible!"

Sparky whimpered as Paul traced the strange, undulating snake-trail up the beach and into the undergrowth. The trail led inland to the bungalow where the boy had been snatched, but on the way there the trail passed directly beneath his hut.

* * *

Chief Narulo summoned Paul to his compound. The Chief had mustered six overweight islanders armed with an assortment of dusty spears, clubs, and shields that normally hung in the Chief's bungalow. Popidou led these warriors, and he carried a cow-skin shield and a rusty old shotgun. He wore a grass skirt and had red paint daubed on his paunchy face.

"It is my duty to protect foreigners from the evil Serpent. You will sleep under my pavilion," the Chief told Paul, who figured he was no longer suspected of surreptitiously eating the island's communal dogs and chickens.

By now Paul had pieced together the situation. For reasons unknown, somebody — French? Russian? American? — had set off a nuclear blast on an island upwind from Rapa Nui. The fallout had drifted down like snow, and the islanders suffered severe radiation sickness. The bomb affected the marine life too; mutations resulted in giant eels that, aside from being vicious, could move on land like snakes. Working together, Man and Mother Nature had created the perfect monster. Paul could not quite swallow his own conclusion, but he had no other explanation.

Meanwhile, he knew their situation to be less than ideal. The monthly supply boat had departed the night before the boy had disappeared; the last plane to land in Rapa Nui had been the one that dropped him off. The island had no two-way radios, no telephones, and no fax machines. The island had no building capable of locking out a giant serpent, and aside from the Chief's out of shape warriors, the islanders had nothing beyond machetes and hatchets for defense. In short, concluded Paul, they were badly fucked.

Paul slept in the Chief's pavilion, a sort of open-walled platform with a thatched roof. On the first night nothing happened; on the second night all passed peacefully as well. On the third night an entire family of seven vanished, and in the morning the islanders found not one but three serpent tracks.

Paul woke on the fourth night when Sparky began to whine. The Chief sat in his wicker chair, jowly head cocked to one side, listening intently. His warriors stood protectively around him. Horrified screams erupted from a distant part of the island, then ceased abruptly.

Soon they could all hear what Sparky had first noticed: a sound like something heavy being pulled over sand and dry palm fronds. Something moved, slow and purposefully, in the dry undergrowth beyond the platform. The warriors raised their spears; Popidou readied his shotgun. The Chief sat motionless, listening, a necklace of sacred talismans clenched in one meaty hand.

Paul pointed his flashlight into the bushes, and they all saw two pale yellow eyes reflected in the light. The eyes blinked, and then suddenly a blurred shape, long and sinuous, launched itself at the platform. Paul saw a grotesque head with a maw of sharp fangs and a long serpent-like body topped with a dorsal fin. He smelled sea-salt and rotten fish.

Popidou fired as the other guards launched their javelins at the yellow eyes; the serpent swung its thick body around violently, breaking the support pillars of the pavilion and knocking all six warriors sprawling. Paul caught a glimpse of the serpent fastening its jaws around the ample midriff of Popidou, and then Paul did what any terrified person would do: he high-tailed it for home.

Paul reached his hut at sunrise. He climbed the ladder and then pulled it up behind him. Sparky hid under the campcot. Paul shut the flimsy door and braced it with the ladder and a crate of heavy English textbooks. He inventoried his meager food and water and gathered his weapons: the heavy rubber flashlight and a short, dull bush knife.

The Peace Corps plane would not come for him until he finished his service in fifteen months; the supply boat would not return for twenty-five days. Paul wondered if he could hold out, or hide out, for that long. He and Sparky crouched in a corner, waiting.

Third Place



Fibber McGee

-Edward Heffernan

Let me tell you the story of Fibber McGee, and the hole to Hell he had in his basement.

This happened long ago, thought not that long; I'm old, but not ancient. I grew up in a small town, like oh so many dotted across the budding nation. This was back in the days when a movie was something you drove into the big city for, when you had to shout into the telephone to be heard, and a penny found on the ground was a precious find. In the days when the air was still clear and the back roads turned to mud in the summer rain.

I am not sure of my exact age at the time. I would have to say it was before my teen years, before girls suddenly held my eyes, when a bug in a jar was hours of amusement, and when the clear night air held a tinge of mystery and fright. Fibber McGee was known around town. Oh, I suppose every town has one: the eccentric character that holds his own way. I used to see him now and again, striding through town with his lanky figure, smoking an ancient corn cob pipe in mouth, walking with long purposeful strides. There were stories about him amongst us children, to be sure. He lived in a large three story house on the edge of town, an isolated memory of architecture before the civil war. My grandfather told me that McGee used to own a curio shop in town, long before I or my parents were birthed into the world. McGee's father had traveled the world, bringing in artifacts and baubles that delighted the eye and provoked a sense of wonder in the world. In that old shop, one could find gorilla hand ashtrays from poachers in Africa, a old and molted copper knife form the days of the Romans, Egyptian haircombs, old and brittle. There were boxes off all shapes and design, little gold boxes holding an herbal snuff used by Asian mystics, large oak chests that held books yellowed and dusty. He had jackalopes,

splinters form the true cross, mummified hands wrapped in aged silk. Oh, there was no end to the wonders.

But McGee's wife had died, and he closed the shop and lived alone in his ancient family house. For the most part, he lived a quiet life, only occasionally coming into town for groceries. There were stories that he lived off a chest of gold doubloons that he kept in the attic, but no one in town had ever seen him pay for anything other than normal American currency. Of course back in those days, people for the most part minded their own business.

Well, most people. There is always the children. Sometimes in the summertime, when the whim took hold of us, we would sneak over to the McGee house to peer in his dusty and cracked windows. You know how it was, children today still do it. A group of giggling youngsters in the bushes, dare and double daring each other to run up and peek in. Then they would run back shrieking with lies that they had seen McGee walking with an ax, or tying up some young child, or dancing with the brittle and mummified corpse of his long dead wife. Tall tales, of course. But those few times I worked up my courage to sprint across the weed filed lawn and stand on my tiptoes to peek into the first story window was always a wonder. For when McGee had closed his shop, he had moved all these wonders into his house. And the sights always sent a thrill up my spine, seeing the strange grandfather clock with the numbers on backwards, old huge tapestry on the far wall of a knight jousting a unicorn, the gargoyle that McGee used to hold a lamp.

This one particular summer, we were doing just that. Earlier that day I had refused to climb to the highest branch of the old oak tree in the center of town, and my reputation had taken its toll. No boy wanted to be a sissy, and only a manly act of courage would bring one back up the status level. I was given the choice of walking across the old drainpipe

that loomed over a gorge behind the courthouse, or I could peek into Fibber McGee's window. Never much of a fan of heights, I gritted my teeth and chose the latter.

I remember that night so clearly, as I sprinted across the lawn, my heart pounding in my chest, the sound of the autumn wind rustling the leaves oh so slightly. I was just peering into the gloom of the window, trying to make sense of the shadows and grayed colors within. That's when I heard his voice.

"Even'n" McGee spoke behind me, and my heart leaped around in my chest like a prize winning bullfrog, and my hair stood on end. I knew I was doomed. In a situation like this, the other boys would not help me. They would run at full speed back into town and swap gruesome tales of what horrors might have befallen me. I slowly turned around and looked up at McGee.

There he was, large as life. The same coveralls he had worn for years, the old and yellowed corncob pipe. But his eyes eased me, they were not the eyes of a madman, or a monster, or any such stereotypes that I read about late at night in horror comics under the bedcovers with my flashlight. Instead they held a friendly twinkle, and a corner of his mouth was twisted into a neighborly smile.

"Trying to sneak a look at my treasures, eh?" he said with a chuckle.

"Y-yesir" I said. Back in those days it was OK for children to talk to strangers, in fact, you were supposed to treat elders with respect. Not much like today.

"Well, all you had to do was knock on the door, youngster." He looked at me gawking wide eyed at him. "I s'pose your looking to see something scary?"

"Yessir" I said. Then suddenly blurted out, "They say you have your dead wife in there." I was horrified I said that, beyond horrified. I was sure I had sealed my fate.

But instead McGee just bend over with

laughter, the wheezy crackling laugh of the elderly. He slapped his knee and tousled my hair.

"Sorry boy, but Bessie is in the town graveyard along with my father. Near thirty years gone it has been." His eyes got a far away look. "Wont be much longer till I join her, I suppose. Been many a year."

He noticed me again, and bent close to my face, close enough for me to see the tobacco stains on his face, the wrinkles around his eyes. "Say boy, there's nothing much scary in there. Just old boxes and older books. They just sit there and collect dust." He leaned closer, speaking to me like an old comrade. "But tell me, do you want to see something really scary?"

By all the Gods in all the Heavens, I did not. I wanted to go home to my bright house where mom was cooking dinner, and listen to the radio. But I could only nod dumbly, and McGee chortled and slapped me on the back and led me into the house.

It was stuffy in the house, and everything had a faint smell of must. McGee led me through a winding maze of bookshelves and crates, of boxes and bangles. Then before one door, he stopped and showed me a cabinet. He turned and grinned at me, and then with a magicians flourish, he opened the cabinet door. Sitting inside on a shelf, with a small layer of dust, stood the largest jar I had ever seen. It must have been three feet tall. Inside the jar, floating in the yellowed liquid of formaldehyde grimaced a nightmare come to life. It looked like the missing link between a sea urchin, and baboon, and the Devil himself. Scrunched up baby face peered back at me with white and dead eyes, its obscenely naked body folded in on itself in the confines of the jar. It seemed to be looking at me.

McGee stared at it, as he quietly refilled his pipe. "My father fished that out from down below, boy. Many years ago. I never did see him do it, he simply told me never to dis-

turb the jar." He peered closer. "Its funny. Peek in now and again, just to look at it. It seems to shift positions sometimes. I have never seen it move, mind you. And its just little things. Maybe the hand was higher, or them dead eyes staring in a different direction."

He shrugged and closed the cabinet, and turned back to me. "Now, you wanna see where my father got it?"

I wanted to say no, say how my mother was waiting for me at the dinnertable. But the sight of that, that thing in the jar had dumbfounded me. And I could only walk mutely as McGee opened a door next to the cabinet and went down the cellar stairs. He spoke quietly as he walked.

"Yessir, this here land is old. Us white people call it the 'new world,' but that's poppycock boy. Its been here a long long time. Before us there was the injuns. And the injuns have tails of things that lived here even before them. The world is old, boy. Always remember that. I nodded mutely as we walked to the back of the cellar, the cold damp air chilling me to the bones. At the very back, McGee pushed aside a large crate, and behold, there's stood a tiny door. Not more than 4 feet tall, it was a perfect square, and was made of what I think was a dark cast-iron metal. Hanging on the doorknob was the largest lock I had ever seen.

McGee held his fingers to his lips for quiet (not that I had been saying much) and put his ear to the door. He crouched there for a minute, face scrunched up in concentration, then he broke out into a wide grin.

"Not a peep in there." He said "not that I've heard anything coming from here in years and years, but it never hurts to be extra careful, eh boy?"

He broke out into a cheery whistle as he brought a keying out from the bib of this overalls. They keys jingled loudly in the quiet

mustiness of the cellar, until he pulled out a large black key that looked to be made of the same material as the door.

"Don't know where this door came from" he muttered as he worked at the old lock, more to himself than to me. "Grandpappy never told muh paw, and so paw never told me. Dunno if it was here first, and then they built the house, or the other way around. Doan really matter much, I guess"

The lock snapped open with a loud clank, and fell to the floor. McGee pushed the door open with a loud squeak, and hustled me inside. I am not sure what I expected to see, perhaps a cavern filled with ghouls, or piles of old bones with misshapen beasts gnawing the marrow out of them. Instead it was simply a very small room, no larger than a closet, with a board on the floor. McGee held me still, and lit a candle on the wall so we could see better. He warned me not to move, and carefully pushed aside the cracked and dirty board. Underneath it was a hole. Just a hole.

"There it is" he said simply. "Back in the old days, my grandpappy used to have problems with things coming out of it. But he was a tough old bastard, like all us McGee's are, and he refused to leave. By time my paw was a teenager, nothing had come out of it for years, and Paw refused to believe there was anything to this old hole. So one night he lowers a bucket down on a rope, thinking it's nothing more than a natural well, or an old cavern. After a while of lowering, he felt something yank on the rope. He was so surprised, he nearly fell in. So he carefully drew the bucket up, thinking maybe it was one of them albino blind cavefish. Instead he brought up that thing you seen in the jar up there. Paw was scared out of his wits, and told me he must whacked that thing with his shovel a hundred times. Grandpappy heard him screaming and ran down the stairs. There he saw paw white as a sheet dumping the corpse of that thing into an old pickle jar. "

Fibber grinned. "And paw got the thrashing of his life.

"I never seen nothing come out of there. But sometimes, late at night, I heard things. Scratching, whisperings, that sort of thing. But nothing ever came out. Or I woulda known."

He picked up a small pebble and tossed it into the hole. I held my breath in the absolute still quite of that little stone chamber, waiting to hear it hit bottom. But it never did. Only a slight smell arose out of it, the smell of something long long dead. Or maybe the smell of something that was never really alive. I shuddered. Fibber saw the shudder, and I think he took pity on me then.

"Go on home, boy. And don't tell no one of this, ya hear?" And led me back up the stairs.

I ran all the way home, until my breath wheezed and a stitch was in my side. Dinner was ready when I got there, and when my father asked me what I had done that day, I just shrugged and said nothing much. And I kept my word, I never told anyone about it, until now. Not the other boys in town, not my mother, not my sweethearts in the years to come.

The McGee house burned down to the ground many years later when I was away in college. No one was sure how the fire started, and it was assumed Fibber McGee burned away with it. They said it was a loss, all those wonderful objects that he had kept in his house. But secretly, I think the town breathed a little easier.

Many years later I visited the spot where the McGee house stood. The soft sloping hills had been paved flat, and a shiny new shopping mall stands there now. It looks so crisp and modern, like it was always there. But I remembered McGee's word. The land it stands on is old. It's all so very old. And I never forgot that.

Second Place

Grim Realization

-Barbara Ann Flowerday
(with credit to K.L.F.)

PARIS, PRESENT DAY

Nowadays most have forgotten that deep below the romantic and sparkling City of Lights lies an equally romantic, albeit in a much different sense, City of the Dead. Far beneath the hurry-scurry wheels of Renaults, Peugeots, and Citroens...beneath the strolling feet of enraptured lovers...beneath the pavement, aged cobblestones and ancient dirt lie the catacombs of Paris.

Honeycombed in dank foul-smelling niches thousands upon thousands of skeletal remains sit in silence. Some sit huddled clutching knobby knees while others lay sprawled in abandon. Some have toppled from their perches to lie in eternal embraces with receptive comrades. Still others have tumbled down, crumbling into fragments and bits that litter the fetid floor. So still it is.

Once the living walked among the dead in the form of guided tours. Oh yes. By lamp-light morbid tourists conducted by jaded guides were shown through the subterranean cemetery. They stumbled clumsily over skeletons and piles of bones. Oohing and Ahhing; feigning fright, while their hearts raced and their eyes fed on the sight like frenzied rats.

Finally, someone high up in the seat of Parisian government had the good taste to put a stop to the ghastly practice and the Catacombs were sealed off leaving the dead at last, in peace.

Le Marquis de l'Aventin was quite at peace. A charming fellow, he was well-liked. One of the few noblemen down below he was accorded certain privileges, but earned the respect of the other's by his unassuming attitude. "Dead was dead," he often said and proved the point by keeping company rather than remaining aloof. A good hand at cards,

he often peppered their games with amusing tales of the nobility his companions had never before been privy to.

Remarkably well preserved, he had been dead near two centuries. Le Marquis always the dandy in life ... and so he was in death; with bones smooth and luminous white he was one of the few who had retained their vestments, and wore to great advantage a moldering silk brocade frockcoat of peacock blue with rotting gold frogging. Only his neck bespoke his violent end. It remained at a permanent 45 angle; a result of the noose that had cut short his amorous activities. Truth be told, it lent him a rakish air.

He had earned the noose for bedding the Queen no less (This made him all the more popular with his current companions). His Royal Majesty, the King, had been so incensed by the incident that to save himself further embarrassment the hanging had taken place quickly and quietly in a private courtyard at Versailles.

Afterward Le Marquis had been cut down and his remains cast into the Catacombs with the common people and petty thieves. A tribute to him, it was purported at the time that the Queen had openly wept for him.

How could such a man so unjustly treated ever hope to find peace? Le Marquis had. In fact he had done so with relative facility. He made peace with his past life posthaste and had embraced the present. He was content; as were most of his compatriots.

The dead do know their place and contrary to what the living believe; they care little for the activities of their breathing brethren.

Whoever first looked upon the countenance of death in the form of a human skull and did not see merriment? The wide eyes so troublefree: no pain, no worries. And the huge rictus of pearly whites. One can come to no other conclusion than that the dead are somehow pleasantly relieved to be shut of all

those concerns. And in how many folktales are there references to dancing skeletons? Dance they do.

Ahh folktales...always in folktales one may find a grain of truth...and so it is true that once a year on the Eve of All Hallows the gates of Hell are thrown open; what is little known, the gates of Heaven open as well. The blessed however have even less interest in the doings of the living than do the damned (And that is why they are always disproportionately represented on Halloween night.)

Now on this particular night Le Marquis had retired early and gathered about him his two closest friends to discuss just this thing.

He proposed an outing. It was a hard sell. With the three of them sitting knee to bony knee in the comfortable dark dispelled only by the hiss of guttering tallow candles, and the warm furry bodies of rats wending their way familiarly about their ankles, even Le Marquis found it difficult to envision leaving such a haven.

But oh what a lark it would be!

More and more he had been dreaming of the flesh, especially the female variety. How he would like to feel something other than the brittle crunch of a pelvic bone beneath him.

Maurice, to the right of him, was horrified. "How can we possibly go out in this state?" he asked, spreading his phalanges to demonstrate the point.

Le Marquis looked on him with fondness. He didn't wonder Maurice was so concerned with his appearance; although a much younger man than himself, Maurice was older dead.

He had been down here at least a hundred years longer and he hadn't weathered well. He was missing his entire lower jaw and there was a grisly bullet hole at his temple.

Maurice was a young innocent murdered in the name of honor, and it was at moments

like this that Le Marquis glimpsed the precious naivete that had gotten the boy killed. Too young he was thrust into the role of being sole protector of his family following the death of his father. Maurice had shouldered the burden with all earnestness. Soon after his little sister was brutally attacked in the woods at the hand of a young Count. The tragedy broke Maurice's heart and he felt he had no choice but to call the other man out to avenge his sister's virtue. The Nobilities code of honor does not extend to commoners and woe to the foolish young man who had presumed to challenge a man of rank.

The Count regarded his opponent as a brash upstart and played him as a cat would a mouse. They met at dawn with pistols and seconds as was the custom. They faced off, and without hesitation the Count shot the pistol from the boy's hand, then walked to where he sat on the ground cradling his wounded hand and placing the still-smoking pistol at Maurice's temple callously shot him dead.

Le Marquis loved the fragility of this boy's soul, it called out to him for protection and strength. He had sheltered Maurice under his wing for near two centuries now down in the depths. Their relationship had transcended mere friendship and they had evolved into almost that of a father and son.

It was Le Marquis that Maurice had entrusted with his detached jawbone; very sensitive about that he was, he could not bear to let a piece of himself simply drop away to join the rubble and forsaken bones on the floor. So in the deep pockets of Le Marquis's frayed frockcoat lay Maurice's mandible, now become a covenant of trust between them.

"Maurice, my young man, where is your spirit, your heart?" Le Marquis asked thumping his breastbone. "Let us have this bit of adventure. All will go well. You forget that we travel under the guise of All Hallow's Eve, we will go lost in the crowd."

Le Marquis turned his attention to the man on his left. "What say you Henri?"

"I think sir, that there are reasons why so few of us venture forth any longer, but I am with you."

Ahh Henri, ever the pragmatist, he was as staid and sober as they come. A perfect balance to the romantic idealism shared by Le Marquis and Maurice. On more than one occasion he had served as their ground.

Henri had lived through the turn of the century. He had witnessed the advent of the motorcar and electricity. His tales, when one could incite him to speak, were more astounding than those of the Le Marquis.

He had made his way into the Catacombs courtesy of a couple of street ruffians; cracked him over the head with a lead pipe to steal his watchfob, turned out his pockets, and rolled him unceremoniously down the stairs to his final resting place.

His badge of courage was the spidery network of cracks over his left eyesocket. And the remaining lump of cartilage that was his nose attested to his distinction of being the newest dead in the house.

Le Marquis bounded up sending the rats skittering in all directions. "Hooray, we are agreed then. Oh what a lark this will be! We meet on the stairs tomorrow at midnight. I take leave of you now, there are plans I must make."

He left Maurice and Henri forlornly looking after him, wondering what they had just gotten themselves into

PARIS, ALL HALLOWS EVE

Some things do not change, and fortunate that was to Le Marquis's plan. After all, what do spirits do but revisit old haunts?

And so it was that after two hundred some years of being absent Le Marquis de l'Aventin with a group of his friends entered the grand ballroom of the Governor's palace,

for *Le Grande Bal Masque de la Veille Toussaint*. And once again Le Marquis was able to rub elbows with his peers; although none were so bony as his.

Upon being ushered into the main salon Le Marquis reeled back and his two companions close by his side steadied him. It was overwhelming. It was uncanny. So much had changed, so much remained the same.

The room itself, still splendid; the same immense crystal chandeliers glittering and tinkling as they swayed slightly in the evening breeze. The same parquet floor his feet had once danced upon partnered with all the young beauties; their faces upturned to his, lush with unspoken promises.

But now amongst the old world amenities were the rather garish trappings of modern revelries: an overabundance of artificial jack o' lanterns, mock webs stretched from this point to that, odd flashing lights. How the other patrons would laugh to know that he found this atmosphere more unsettling than the one he had just recently left behind.

The whirling couples, he stood in their midst and was buffeted by their silken gowns and plumes, their capes and props, their hats and ornate masks, their heady perfumes; this was familiar. These were his people, the nobility, the wealthy and privileged.

He started searching their faces for someone familiar and suddenly came up short: everyone who knew him had been dead for at least two centuries. These were the faces of descendants so far removed as to not matter at all.

Maurice and Henri sensed his pain and steered him towards a set of doors hung with billowing diaphanous draperies that hid their uncertainty.

Le Marquis waved them away. "Forgive me, I was unprepared...." He looked up, there was no need to go on, his sentiments were echoed in their eyes. They did not belong.

It was Henri who rescued the moment. "I believe I need a drink," he declared expansively. "A good stiff one."

A feminine voice to their immediate right answered back, "That's what the ladies like ..." and out from the shadows stepped a spellbinding female.

Spellbinding mostly due to her marked lack of attire. Got up like some harem slave she undulated to the side of Le Marquis. "I've been watching you. What fabulous costumes ... so frightful I could just faint." She continued batting her lashes and latched onto Le Marquis's arm. "Are you Americans? Hollywood?"

"You're the scariest man here," she simpered on, looking full into his face now, and still not flinching. He could smell the alcohol coming off of her in waves. She swayed and he steadied her with his arm.

Maurice and Henri had melted into the shadows leaving him alone with the little trollop. He remembered back to the cultured and refined ladies of his time. So charming and genteel they could inspire a man's devotion. He sighed.

Meanwhile, Maurice was leading Henri through the streets of Paris. The city sparkled as neither man had seen it before. Holiday revelers cavorted in costumes both shocking and inventive. Le Marquis had been right, in their fine clothes no one gave them a second look.

At the outskirts of the city Maurice came to such an abrupt halt that Henri in rushing to keep up, stumbled right into him. "What? What is it?"

Maurice was on his knees, his arms hung straight to his sides. The metacarpals of his hands making as eerie skritch-skritch sound on the cobbles with each rocking motion. His head hung down, he was weeping.

In front of him stood an old soot-covered brick factory. It's stacks even now, at this time

of the night belching out acrid black smoke. Ugly metallic grinding noises came from within.

"What is this place?" Henri asked.

From his knees Maurice answered "It is my farm, my family's farm, and I know not what became of them...."

Henri tenderly laid his hand on Maurice's shoulder "My friend, what did you expect?"

He helped Maurice to his feet. "Come let us rejoin Le Marquis and make our way back. This is no longer our world."

* * *

Le Marquis was torn. He was alternately attracted to, then repulsed by this woman. He found her to be exceedingly vulgar and crass on one hand, then in the next moment he was disarmed by her charming candor.

And he wanted a woman.

They were on a settee at the fringes of the dance floor. She had just left off pressing his hand to her incredible breasts. "They're fake you know ... bet you couldn't tell. Just had them done."

What on earth was she talking about? He had no idea. The feel of them was real enough if his memory served.

Where was Maurice and Henri? There were but two hours left.

It was then, when he was distracted, that her hand shot out. In horror he watched as it fell into his lap, and began digging for his breeches. He was paralyzed. With dread fascination he waited for her to come across the gaping cavity inside his pelvic girdle.

His eyes locked onto hers awaiting the moment of discovery. Suddenly her hand finished it's fumbling and began a stroking motion. He watched in amazement as a look of pure satisfaction came over her face. She looked rather like a cat with a mouthful of bird, so pleased she was with herself.

Then it dawned on him: her hand had

found the long smooth edge of Maurice's mandible secreted in the pocket of his frock-coat.

He chuckled to himself. Poor Maurice ! He would surely die a second death if he only knew the purpose his estranged body part had been put to.

The silly creature was whipping herself into a frenzy. She was flushed in the face and breathing so heavily now that they were beginning to receive quizzical stares. Never one for public displays, Le Marquis gently extricated himself from her grasp and swept her up into his arms. He had been born, lived, and died a ladies man.

In her boudoir the lights extinguished all but one, clothes flew like leaves in a wind-storm. Behind gauzy rose curtains he found himself straddled upon her. She was thrashing beneath him in ecstasy before he even touched her.

What was he doing? What could he do?

He didn't know.

But there was warm soft flesh beneath him, and that was a revelation.

Suddenly, without warning, the door was thrown open and the lights came on.

"Sacre Bleu !"

Le Marquis looked around to find a portly gentleman standing framed in the doorway. Both anger and revulsion mottled his skin red.

Beneath Le Marquis, reality had finally penetrated the alcoholic haze and raging hormones; the woman let out a scream that peeled paint from the walls.

Le Marquis was up and into his frockcoat. How tiring this was all becoming. He bowed to the lady cowering in the bed and with a, *"Pardonnez moi,"* directed to her husband, brushed past the poor man who had fallen back against the wall in his haste to get away from the terrible form before him.

Down the formal staircase he made his way finding a path through the drunken revellers to the door. Those that had imbibed less shrank from him, clapping hands over screaming mouths; all but his frockcoat had been left behind wantonly discarded on the lady's floor. The bells outside tolled 4:00 a.m.

* * *

The streets had grown quiet. Pink fingers of dawn crept stealthily up from the horizon, backlighting the skeletal trees and the wash of leaves at their feet.

Maurice and Henri stumbled in their haste, feeling horribly exposed; afraid at any moment to hear a shriek that would signal their discovery. They rounded the corner and saw the lone figure seated halfway up the stairs to the Governor's mansion.

The sight tugged at their hearts and caused them to slow in their tracks. Such a stark lonely figure they had never before seen.

Le Marquis sat with his head bowed in desolation, his arms straight out, the phalanges trailing over the cold lip of a marble stair. He must have been there for a while for a pile of vagabond leaves had come to rest in a puddle about his feet.

He looked up when they approached. Le Marquis extended his hand to Maurice who took it in his own.

"Maurice, my boy, I am afraid I have done a terrible thing," and with that he let his hand drop.

Maurice looked at him in consternation.

"I have lost what you entrusted to me I have lost your mandible." He proceeded to tell them of his calamitous encounter with the female and his ensuing flight. "I think it must have dropped out of my pocket.... I am so deeply sorry Maurice."

A single fat teardrop fell from Maurice's eyesocket as he placed his hand in consola-

tion on Le Marquis' shoulder. " You need not think twice on it sir."

Dawn was imminent now, the birds had begun to sing. Maurice helped Le Marquis to his feet and turned to collect Henri, who had been silent during the exchange. He was not there.

* * *

Inside party detritus was everywhere and the sickening smell of stale champagne hung in the air. Henri bounded up the stairs taking three at a time, pushing past startled chambermaids and shoving aside the drunken vestiges of last night's partygoers. At the top of the stairs he began flinging open doors sending them crashing into the walls. People began shouting hysterically.

Finally he came to the correct door, which now hung in splinters on it's frame. In bed he recognized the little tart who had accosted Le Marquis. Meanwhile she began shrieking at the top of her lungs, scrambling into a sitting position, and clutching the sheet to her bosom.

"Have no fear Madame, I've seen more attractive décolletage on my most current female companions."

With relief he spied on the floor what he was after. Maurice's mandible lay incongruously next to a fussy little *frou-frou* slipper discarded by the bed. He strode to the bed and snatched it up. The woman, wide eyed and whimpering saw what he held in his hand and fainted dead away.

* * *

Outside on the steps Maurice and Le Marquis were beside themselves. Where was Henri ?

The morning sun had now broken over the treetops. They were quite sure they were breaking some cardinal rule of the dead by being there to witness it. Surely God had never intended such a thing. And what a

ghastly sight they were by the light of the day!

At that moment Henri came bursting through the double doors of the Governor's mansion, and what a racket he was accompanied by: a chorus of terrified screams.

He ran pell-mell past them down the stairs, pausing only long enough to press something into Maurice's metacarpals. He pulled them along after him and the three took flight.

Upon returning, they were the celebrities of the Catacombs. Over and over again they were made to tell of their adventure. Le Marquis was the good natured recipient of much ribald ribbing. Henri was the hero that saved the day. Maurice was sympathized with, and being the sensitive type was asked for his impressions of the world.

When finally the hubbub had died down and their companions moved off to their own corners with new bits of knowledge to chew on, their gaiety fell away as had years before their rotting flesh. They had had a bad scare, and none of them wanted so much as to pretend they had never been abroad.

They settled back comfortably into their niches, arranged the cobwebs about them, stroked the rats, and agreed it was good to be back home again.

After a while they fell into an easy silence and all one could hear was the clickety-clack of brittle old bones and the ivory mah jong pieces. And so they settled into their game, assured in the knowledge that it was far better to be dead, than to live in the hell above.

First Place